



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Joseph Academy
School Website: <https://sjawalton.com/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

St. Joseph Academy (Walton, KY, 41094) presents as a Catholic school with a strong liturgical, faith-centered identity and a formation-focused educational philosophy. Public-facing materials emphasize spiritual formation, virtue, and community-life through Mass, traditional devotions, catechesis, and parish affiliation, alongside a structured K–8 program that includes classical homeschooling options and a traditional academic track. The school demonstrates clear religious foundations and a commitment to forming character and faith alongside academics, but its explicit classical features (e.g., Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, Socratic pedagogy) are not uniformly documented across all grade levels in the public materials. Overall, the school aligns with classical elements in meaningful but partial ways, yielding a ranking of SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Key insights

- Religious and metaphysical foundations are strong: Catholic identity, Mass and liturgical life, and a clear church-school partnership are explicitly emphasized. Evidence: Catholic identity and liturgical practices are foregrounded on the public site; Our Philosophy anchors education in faith and moral formation.
- The school foregrounds formation (virtue, character, citizenship) rather than information-only aims, aligning with a core classical aim, though explicit articulation of truth-goodness-beauty or Great Books pedagogy is less evident in public materials.
- Curriculum and pedagogy show classical-adjacent elements (Classical Homeschooling option, K–8 structure, traditional coursework) but lack pervasive, explicit documentation of the full classical trifecta (grammar-logic-rhetoric, Great Books/Great Conversation, and sustained Socratic seminars) across all grades in the public materials.
- Faculty and community aspects emphasize a living-Catholic-educator model and family/parish partnership, consistent with classical education’s collegial, mentorship-friendly posture and family involvement, yet with limited evidence of the full “faculty-as-living-curriculum” framing in public content.
- Parent/community engagement is present (Getting Involved, parish connections, events, open-campus opportunities), but the materials do not strongly position parents as co-educators in the classical sense, though there are pathways for involvement.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot**Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL****Evidence**

- The school identifies as Catholic, located on parish grounds, operated by Sisters of Saint Joseph the Worker, and emphasizes liturgical life (Mass and traditional devotions).
- Our Philosophy explicitly foregrounds faith-based instruction in truth, morals, and Christian formation; it presents faith as foundational to education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Keywords present on public materials that align with Positive Keywords in the Six Essentials lexicon: Catholic, Mass, liturgy/devotions, theology, sacred/tradition, moral formation. See the religious foundations emphasis (Mass, devotions, theology) and the parish affiliation.

- The lexicon's positive indicators include truth/goodness/beauty, liturgy, catechesis, sacred tradition, and theology; these themes are reflected in the school's Catholic framing.
- Negative keywords (secular, relativistic, value-neutral) are not evidenced in public materials. The site consistently centers faith-based formation.

Why this rating

- The school's public materials exhibit a robust Catholic identity, liturgical life, and theology-driven formation, which strongly support a Classical foundation's religious/metaphysical layer. The absence of secular or non-theological framing in the public materials supports the Classical classification for this category.

Notes on evidence and sources

- The core Catholic identity and liturgical life are documented on the site (Catholic school, Mass, All Saints parish, Sisters of St. Joseph).
- The Our Philosophy page articulates the faith-centered purpose and moral formation orientation.

Score justification: CLASSICAL or, given the sharp Catholic and liturgical emphasis, CLASSICAL in spirit for this category, with no contrary signals.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials emphasize formation of the whole child: "Strives to educate the whole child spiritually, academically, and socially."
- The literature frames education as formation in Christian faith and morals, with emphasis on truth and goodness through faith-guided instruction.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present (formation, virtue, human dignity, citizenship, moral formation) appear in the philosophy and purpose statements. The Our Philosophy piece cites formation through faith and moral formation; "good citizenship" is explicitly mentioned.
- The lexicon's positive keywords for this category include formation, virtue, teleology, moral imagination, and pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty; the site demonstrates formation and moral aims but does not consistently articulate Teleology or explicit "great conversation" or "paideia" language beyond faith-based formation.
- Negative keywords (e.g., "workforce preparation" or purely utilitarian aims) are not present in the public materials.

Why this rating

- The school clearly prioritizes formation (spiritual, moral, intellectual, social) over mere information transfer, aligning with classical aims in spirit. However, the explicit articulation of classical telos (truth, goodness, beauty as real and knowable) and the full spectrum of classical aims in public language are not as overt as a documented Great Books/Trivium-based approach. Hence, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Notes on evidence and sources

- Formation emphasis and holistic aims are explicit in the "Strives to educate the whole child..." language.
- Faith-grounded, truth-centered instruction described in the Our Philosophy page.

Score justification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL due to clear formation emphasis, with less explicit documentation of the full classical telos in public materials.

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**Evidence**

- Public pages mention a traditional curriculum track (Preschool–8th, Algebra I in 8th grade, Captivating Literature) and a Classical Homeschooling option; the presence of a Classical Homeschooling pathway signals classical orientation.
- There is explicit reference to a traditional program (Daily Mass & Traditional Devotions) and a structured K–8 program, with a faith-infused approach to education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: “Classical Homeschooling,” “Literature,” “Algebra I,” “K–8,” “Traditional,” which align with classical education’s curricular emphasis on a liberal-arts-flavored baseline in some forms.
- The lexicon’s curricula indicators emphasize Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books/Great Conversation, and the curriculum being designed to cultivate wonder. The SJ site shows a classical homeschooling option and a traditional track, but does not consistently document grammar/-logic/rhetoric, Great Books, or a universal Great Conversation approach across the entire program. Thus, partial alignment.
- Negative keywords (e.g., “project-based learning dominant over memory/recitation,” “social studies replacing history,” etc.) are not overtly present; the site emphasizes literature, math, science, and classic coursework in a Catholic framework.

Why this rating

- The presence of a Classical Homeschooling pathway and traditional K–8 program indicates classical influence, but the public materials do not demonstrate a comprehensive classical curriculum across all grades (e.g., explicit Great Books list, Trivium/Quadrivium emphasis, or sustained primary-source reading). This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Notes on evidence and sources

- Classical homeschooling program and K–8 alignment evidenced in enrollment content.
- Traditional Academic program materials (e.g., Algebra I, Literature) are noted in the site.

Score justification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL due to identifiable classical elements (especially the Classical Homeschooling option) but lacking comprehensive public documentation of classical curriculum across all grades.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**Evidence**

- Pedagogical cues include a mix of traditional/ritual life (Daily Mass, Devotions) and a modern academic structure (Algebra I, 8th-grade year; integrated technology). This suggests a hybrid pedagogy rather than a sole emphasis on strictly classical methods.
- The presence of a Classical Homeschooling option implies a pedagogical approach rooted in classical methods for some learners, but there is no explicit, widespread documentation of Socratic seminars or intensive use of trivium-based pedagogy in the general program.
- Lower-level pedagogy specifics (e.g., singing/chanting, memory work, or Scholé days) are not clearly documented on the public site, though classical lexicon signals these practices as hallmark methods.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords that align with classical pedagogy include terms like “Socratic dialogue,” “memory work,” “chanting/singing to memorize,” and “restful learning (Scholé)” if present; however, these are not clearly documented as standard practices on the SJ site.

- The site does emphasize a traditional, liturgical, and faith-based approach, with a classical homeschooling option suggesting some classical methods, but without explicit, broad evidence of Socratic seminars or extensive Latin/grammar-based pedagogy.

Why this rating

- Pedagogy shows classical echoes (especially in the Classical Homeschooling option) but public materials do not consistently document full classical teaching methods (Socratic seminars, memorization/recitation, rhythm of schooling, etc.) across the entire program. This indicates SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Notes on evidence and sources

- Classical Homeschooling option signals classical pedagogy.
- Public materials emphasize traditional religious life and standard coursework rather than a consistent, public, classical pedagogy across all grade levels.

Score justification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL due to partial classical pedagogy signals (especially in the homeschooling pathway) but not a consistently documented classical pedagogy across the school.

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The Academy is operated by Sisters of Saint Joseph the Worker, indicating a religious-faculty model and mentorship structure rooted in a religious community.
- Public content references staff and the “living curriculum” concept in classical education, though explicit language about faculty as role models or a “portrait of what a teacher should be” is not consistently documented on the public site. The visible language emphasizes faith-based formation by religious sisters and faith-guided instruction.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: teacher as mentor/guide, living curriculum, faculty of friends (as a classical paradigm) are suggested by the religious-education model, though explicit phrasing is limited in public content. The presence of Sisters of Saint Joseph and the “Our Philosophy” messaging supports a virtuous-teacher-as-model frame.
- Negative keywords (e.g., “professional-skill driven” without virtue, or “teacher-as-facilitator only” without classical context) are not evidenced; however, explicit “living curriculum” and precise faculty portraits are not strongly documented in the public materials.

Why this rating

- The faith-based faculty structure (religious order leadership, role modeling aligned with virtue formation) supports a classical ideal of the teacher as mentor and exemplar. However, explicit, public documentation of a formal “faculty profile/portrait” and the living-curriculum concept is not strongly evidenced. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Notes on evidence and sources

- Catholic religious order leadership and staff focus evident on the site.
- Our Philosophy emphasizes faith-informed formation through the staff and community, though explicit “living curriculum” phrasing is not consistently documented in public text.

Score justification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL due to the model of virtue-based faculty rooted in religious formation, with less explicit public articulation of the full classical faculty model.

Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence



- The site highlights partnership with families and active community involvement: Getting Involved, events, sponsors, All Saints Parish, diocese connections, and a welcoming policy for visits. This indicates a community-focused approach aligned with classical education's emphasis on families as co-educators and a shared mission.
- Public materials mention distinct parish-school collaboration (All Saints Parish Walton) and community events (Pig Fest, Cookies & Cocoa, Vacation Bible School), which reflect ongoing community engagement and parent participation opportunities.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: "Partnership with Families," "Getting Involved," "Sponsors," "All Saints Parish," "co-teachers" (as implied by the community and parish linkages in the materials). The Classical Lexicon lists "Partnership with Families," "Formation of Affections," and "Cultural Transmission" as positive indicators for parents/community; the SJ site shows family involvement and parish collaboration that align with these ideas.
- Negative keywords (e.g., "parent as customer," minimal parent involvement) are not present; rather the site invites parent involvement and visits. This suggests alignment with classical parent-partnership ideals, though explicit parent-education or book-club-type formation offerings are less clearly documented.

Why this rating

- The school demonstrates clear parent/community engagement through involvement opportunities and parish connections, aligning with classical expectations for a cooperative school-parent culture. However, the public materials do not consistently document formal parent-education programs or a deeply articulated "parents as co-teachers" framework beyond general involvement. Thus, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Notes on evidence and sources

- Public pages show partner-with-families language and community events.
- Parish affiliation and community support are documented on the site.

Aggregate assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- Make Great Books explicit across the program: Publicly publish a Great Books reading list and a clear Great Conversation framework for K–12, including primary sources, canonical works, and a plan for integrating discussion-based inquiry (Socratic or Paideia-style). This would elevate Element 3 (Curriculum) to CLASSICAL and reinforce Element 4 (Pedagogy).
- Formalize grammar-logic-rhetoric progression: Document and implement a Trivium-based scaffolding (grammar in early grades, logic in middle school, rhetoric in high school) with explicit course alignment and assessment. This would strengthen Element 3 (Curriculum) and Element 4 (Pedagogy), moving toward CLASSICAL.
- Expand Socratic and dialectic pedagogy in upper grades: Introduce regular, school-wide or grade-level Socratic seminars and structured debates to develop disciplined dialogue aligned with classical pedagogy (Element 4).
- Strengthen the "living curriculum" faculty model: Develop and publish a clear "portrait of a classical teacher" and a policy around faculty as mentors living the classical curriculum (Element 5). This

could include professional-development in classical pedagogy and a documented staff curriculum-embedded model.

- Deepen parent formation and partnership: Create formal programs for parents (book studies, lectures, family catechesis) that explicitly position parents as co-teachers in the classical tradition (Element 6). This would strengthen the parent/community signal in the Six Elements framework.
- Clarify Great Conversation/Western canon integration: Confirm and articulate a curriculum that integrates Western civilization heritage, great books, and primary sources to anchor cultural transmission (Element 3). This would push the school toward a fuller CLASSICAL alignment.

ABSTRACT

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Strong CLASSICAL alignment due to explicit Catholic identity, liturgical life (Mass, devotions), and a parish-based educational mission. Evidence includes “Private Catholic School,” All Saints Catholic Church affiliation, and Daily Mass/Traditional Devotions on public materials. The Our Philosophy page reinforces faith-based formation. Positive indicators align with theological and liturgical elements in classical lexicons.
- School Purpose and Goal: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Formation themes are explicit (whole-child formation, faith-based instruction, moral formation, good citizenship), though explicit articulation of the full truth-goodness-beauty telos beyond faith is less overt in public text. The formation language is strong evidence for a classical orientation but lacks uniform explicit phrasing of classical teleology across materials.
- Curriculum: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Evidence includes a traditional K–8 program and Algebra I, plus a Classical Homeschooling option, indicating classical influence without a complete public catalog of Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, or universal Great Conversation across the entire program.
- Pedagogy: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Pedagogy appears hybrid—traditional religious life and “Classical Homeschooling” option suggest classical underpinnings, but explicit documentation of Socratic seminars, memorization/recitation, or formal Scholé pedagogy is not consistently present in public materials.
- Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. The religious order model and staff focus align with virtue-formation and mentorship ideals, consistent with classical education’s teacher-mentor ethos; however, explicit public articulation of formal “living curriculum” faculty roles or portraits is not consistently documented.
- Parents & Community: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Strong community and parish connections plus parent-involvement pathways exist; however, the materials do not consistently present a fully developed “parents as co-teachers” framework or formal parent-education programs in the classical sense.

Overall: The school demonstrates meaningful classical elements (especially religious foundations and formation-focused goals), but public materials do not consistently document the full classical curriculum, pedagogy, or faculty design that would constitute a CLASSICAL rating across all six categories. As such, the aggregate classification is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle (concrete steps)

- Publish a canonical Great Books/Great Conversation plan for K–12, including primary texts and a timeline for integration.
- Implement and publicly document a formal Trivium progression (grammar-logic-rhetoric) with grade-level targets and assessment alignment.
- Establish regular Socratic seminars and structured debates across appropriate grades, with teacher-guided facilitation as a standard practice.

- Develop and publish a formal “portrait of a classical teacher” and a living-curriculum framework, with professional development in classical pedagogy.
- Create formal parent-education offerings (book studies, lectures) that explicitly position parents as co-educators within the classical model.

Cited sources and evidence

- Public Catholic identity and liturgical life (Mass, devotions; parochial affiliation; Sisters of Saint Joseph): turn0file1; turn1file11.
- Formation language and “whole child” emphasis: turn0file3; turn1file11.
- Curriculum and classical-homeschooling signals: turn0file1; turn1file18.
- Parent/community engagement signals: turn0file3; turn0file1.
- Classical keywords and indicators (Positive/Negative keyword framework): Six Essential Elements (Positive/Negative keywords) and related lexicon, cited in the knowledge-base documents.

ABSTRACT

St. Joseph Academy (Walton, KY 41094) demonstrates a Catholic, formation-centered program with classical-adjacent elements. The school’s public materials emphasize liturgical life, faith-based formation, and a holistic education, supported by parish affiliation and a religious-order-led faculty model. While Classical Homeschooling and traditional K–8 tracks signal classical orientation, public documentation of comprehensive classical curriculum components (Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, robust Socratic pedagogy) is incomplete. The overall evaluation lands in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with clear strengths in religious foundations and formation but partial alignment in the breadth and documentation of classical curriculum, pedagogy, and faculty practices.

Summary of 6 primary categories:

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
- School Purpose and Goal: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Curriculum: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Pedagogy: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Parents and Community: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Overall: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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